

Valley Fever — What you need to know

Coccidioidomycosis · A common Arizona desert lung infection

Valley Fever is an infection caused by a fungus called *Coccidioides*. The fungus lives in dry desert soil, especially in southern Arizona. People and animals get Valley Fever by breathing in dust that contains the fungus's spores — usually after a windstorm, dust storm, or any activity that disturbs the soil (digging, construction, gardening, off-road driving).

Symptoms

- Cough that lasts more than two weeks
- Fever, often low-grade
- Tiredness that doesn't go away
- Chest pain or shortness of breath
- Headache
- Skin rash on the upper body or legs (sometimes)
- Joint pain, especially knees and ankles

What you should do

1. Take all medications exactly as prescribed. Most people are treated with an antifungal pill called **fluconazole** for at least 3 to 6 months.
2. Rest. Valley Fever is a slow infection. Even mild cases take weeks to recover from.
3. Tell your doctor right away if symptoms worsen — especially if you have new headaches, stiff neck, weight loss, or weakness on one side of the body. These can be signs the infection has spread.
4. Do not stop your medication early, even if you feel better. The infection can come back.
5. Drink plenty of water and avoid alcohol while on antifungal medication.

If your dog or other pet was diagnosed first

Valley Fever is **not contagious between people, or between pets and people**. But everyone in the household was likely exposed to the same dust. If your dog was diagnosed first, that does not mean the dog gave it to you — it means the soil around your home or yard had the fungus, and you all breathed it in. Tell your doctor about the household exposure; it helps make the diagnosis faster.

Recovery

Most healthy adults recover fully from Valley Fever, but it can take 6 months to a year. About 1 out of 200 people develops a more serious form that needs lifelong treatment. People with weakened immune systems, pregnant women, and people of African or Filipino descent are at higher risk for severe disease.

Call 911 or go to the emergency room if you have:

- Severe difficulty breathing
- Chest pain that doesn't go away
- Confusion, severe headache, or stiff neck
- Weakness on one side of the body or trouble speaking

More information

- Arizona Department of Health Services Valley Fever Program: 602-364-3676
- CDC Valley Fever page: cdc.gov/fungal/diseases/coccidioidomycosis
- Valley Fever Center for Excellence (University of Arizona): vfce.arizona.edu

ONE-HealthRecord MVP · Synthetic demonstration · Content drawn from public CDC and Arizona Department of Health Services plain-language disease pages. This handout is informational and does not replace medical advice from your clinician.